



Structural barriers to sufficiency: the contribution of research on elites

MAX KOCH

KAJSA EMILSSON

JAYEON LEE

HÅKAN JOHANSSON

*Author affiliations can be found in the back matter of this article

SPECIAL COLLECTION:
ENERGY SUFFICIENCY
IN BUILDINGS AND
CITIES

RESEARCH

ubiquity press

ABSTRACT

‘Sufficiency’ has become a key term within sustainability science. The satisfaction of basic human needs for all and for multiple generations is only possible if coupled to the implementation of ecological ceilings that prevent wealthy groups from disproportionate production and consumption patterns and energy use. While much sufficiency research has focused on the poor and how to provide corresponding social floors (i.e. an adequate level of sufficiency), this conceptual paper theorises structural barriers to implementing ecological ceilings for production and consumption by considering research on elites. The argument is illustrated with examples from urban spaces that are increasingly structured to accommodate the preferences of economic elites. A better scholarly understanding of the structural barriers to sufficiency dissemination can be facilitated through a systematic account of the political, social and symbolic strategies deployed by elites to accumulate and legitimise power. Conversely, a consideration of sufficiency principles would also be beneficial for research on elites, which has so far focused on social inequality and sidelined the ecological crisis. The discussion highlights how research on sufficiency and elite consumption may interact to be mutually beneficial. A research agenda is proposed to understand economic elites as barriers to the dissemination of sufficiency principles.

POLICY RELEVANCE

Economic elites have a disproportionate ecological footprint if planetary boundaries are taken seriously and respected in policymaking. In an ecologically constrained planet, elite lifestyles undermine the satisfaction of basic needs of most of the population and future generations. Nevertheless, elites count as role models. This critical literature review reveals the separate traditions of research on sufficiency and elites, the political, social and symbolic strategies that economic elites employ to justify their privileged status in times of climate emergency and social–ecological transformation. These strategies are presented as major structural barriers to the dissemination of sufficiency principles that policymakers must consider when promoting and realising alternative and sustainable production and consumption patterns. The enormity of this task is illustrated by the fact that few people currently support policy measures to regulate economic elites via, for example, caps on income and wealth.

CORRESPONDING AUTHOR: Max Koch

School of Social Work, Lund
University, Box 23, 22100 Lund,
SE

max.koch@soch.lu.se

KEYWORDS:

built environment; climate
emergency; ecological limits;
economic elites; energy
demand; inequality; lifestyles;
overconsumption; socio-
ecological transformation;
sufficiency; sustainable welfare

TO CITE THIS ARTICLE:

Koch, M., Emilsson, K., Lee, J., &
Johansson, H. (2024). Structural
barriers to sufficiency: the
contribution of research on
elites. *Buildings and Cities*, 5(1),
pp. 268–282. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.5334/bc.439>

The sustainability of contemporary society is in danger of collapsing under the weight of a dual and interrelated crisis. While the social crisis dimension manifests itself in levels of inequality last seen in the 19th century (Piketty *et al.* 2023), the most discussed aspects of the ecological crisis are the climate (IPCC 2022) and biodiversity (IPBES 2022) emergencies. ‘Sufficiency’ has deservedly become a key term within sustainability science. While much sufficiency research has focused on the poor and how to provide corresponding social floors to satisfy basic human needs within planetary limits and behavioural change, there is a lack of interest in the ‘top’ of society: elite lifestyles and how these undermine the dissemination of sufficiency principles. However, on an ecologically constrained planet the provision of sufficiency for the many is linked to limitations of the few—here referred to as economic elites—that are leading ecologically ungeneralisable lifestyles (Gössling & Humpe 2023). The satisfaction of basic human needs for all and over time is only possible if coupled to the implementation of ecological ceilings that prevent wealthy individuals and groups from disproportionate production and consumption patterns and energy use (Khan *et al.* 2023).

This paper explores the extent to which research can help understand how the wealthiest in society exercise power to impede the dissemination and implementation of sufficiency principles. This can aid understanding of why many people are sceptical about eco-social measures involving ecological ceilings such as caps on income and wealth or living space limitations.¹ However, research has so far focused on social inequality and patterns of elite reproduction and their legitimisation (Savage & Hjellbrekke 2021) and largely sidelined the ecological crisis. Hence, it would benefit from an integration with sustainability science in general and sufficiency research in particular. To provide such an integration, this conceptual paper provides a critical review of the sufficiency debate and the state of research on elites. It proposes ways to combine elements from both as a precondition to launch empirical research into the understanding of economic elites in social–ecological transformations and as barriers to the dissemination of sufficiency principles.

The paper is structured as follows. By reviewing the existing literatures on sufficiency (in general and applied to energy consumption and urban spaces) and limitarianism, it first identifies the research gap that consists in an adequate consideration of economic elites in connection with the social–ecological crisis. The subsequent section introduces the state-of-the-art of elite research highlighting relevant patterns of economic and symbolic capital employment to occupy and legitimise privileged positions in society and disproportionate ecological footprints of the corresponding lifestyles. This is illustrated with reference to urban spaces as arenas that are increasingly structured to accommodate the lifestyles and preferences of economic elites. The discussion outlines the potential for mutual benefit of an integration of elite and sufficiency research and sketches a corresponding empirical research agenda.

2. (ENERGY) SUFFICIENCY AND LIMITARIANISM

A recent systematic review of the sufficiency literature (Jungell-Michelsson & Heikkurinen 2022: 4) locates at the core of the concept the:

idea that reaching a state of ‘enough’ is desirable both from the perspective of ecosystems, as well as from the point of view of social and economic systems.

The authors point out that the ‘sufficiency’ concept is often applied when the necessity of ‘bringing production and consumption systems within natural limits [...]’ (5) is emphasised. Darby & Fawcett (2018: 8) define sufficiency in similar terms—an ‘amount of something that is enough for a particular purpose’—and understand energy sufficiency as the:

state in which people’s basic needs for energy services are met equitably and ecological limits are respected.

As in the sustainable welfare literature, which focuses on the intersection of welfare and social policy and environmental sustainability issues (Koch *et al.* 2023), it is argued that the centrality

of human needs within sufficiency research and as a distinct category from ‘wants’ necessitates the theorising and empirical identification of a line between the two. In a further homology to sustainable welfare, Darby & Fawcett (2018) apply Doyal & Gough’s (1991) theory of human need which identified two basic needs (physical and mental health as well as autonomy) and 11 ‘intermediate needs’, whereby needs satisfiers vary across cultures, localities and time. According to Gough (2017), minimum standards representing objective human needs can be collectively deliberated (Guillén-Royo 2016) and, in some instances, ‘translated’ into monetary minimum income standards (Davis et al. 2022). The latter is the equivalent to a basket of goods and services:

required by different types of households in order to meet these needs and to participate in society.

(Darby & Fawcett 2018: 12; see also Padley & Hirsch 2017)

To achieve energy sufficiency, strategies are being discussed that have the potential of reducing energy demand. Bierwirth & Thomas (2019: 6) relate this to the areas of space, design and construction, equipment and use. To take the example of space, the sizes of buildings and their technical equipment continuously increased over the last decades. Despite technological progress leading to relative energy efficiency, additional floor space has required more energy for heating and cooling, ventilation, and lighting (Lorek & Sprangenberg 2019: 288). The overall result of such rebound effects is that energy efficiency gains have so far not led to an absolute reduction in final energy use in buildings (Bierwirth & Thomas 2019: 7; see also Rees 2009). The general trend towards increasing building and floor sizes in rich countries has taken an uneven form as increasingly less affordable space has been made available for social housing and poorer income groups, while correspondingly more room has been provided for luxury buildings both for private (under)use and transnational business operations (Nelson 2019; Burrows & Knowles 2019). While increasing amounts of housing units have become unaffordable for growing numbers of people, significant shares of the available housing stock is being unused. Schneider (2019: 21) estimates that there are ‘more than 10 million “empty houses” and 4 million homeless people Europe-wide’. Atkinson (2018) refers to the relationship between globally mobile super-rich groups and property development that generate large volumes of underused or ‘dead’ residential space as ‘necroecture’ with adverse consequences for public life and livelihood. Especially larger cities have become spaces not merely of gentrification but increasingly of ‘supergentrification’ where already prosperous middle-class areas are ‘upgraded’ to exclusive areas as the most affluent groups ‘were able to impose their will and vision on neighbourhoods’ (Paulsen & Stuber 2022: 6; see also Burrows & Knowles 2019 who refer to these processes as beyond supergentrification). Housing is increasingly dominated by super-rich financiers who tend to view it as an investment rather than ‘a space to be fully occupied’ (Burrows & Knowles 2019: 7).²

There are attempts to interpret sufficiency more broadly than in terms of providing minimums at levels corresponding to basic human need satisfaction or what may count as ‘enough’. Spengler (2016: 936) suggests considering:

the adverse environmental (and other) impacts of the consumption patterns in wealthy countries, thus seeking to establish maximum levels of consumption.

Recent approaches to identify consumption (Fuchs et al. 2021) and production (Bärnthaler & Gough 2023) ‘corridors’ in line with ecological ceilings point in the same direction. Robeyns (2017) develops this idea further, from the perspective of a ‘problem-driven political philosophy’. She introduces the notion of ‘limitarianism’ and the view that no individual should have more than a maximum or an upper threshold of income and wealth. She advocates a relational approach, proposing that the subordinate situations in which the poor find themselves are causally linked to the relative privileged positions in social space of the rich.³ A problematisation of inequality and ecologically ungeneralisable social practices of the rich is considered necessary in a world where many people are ‘unable to flourish’ and where there are ‘major collective action problems’ including the biodiversity and climate crises. However:

large holdings of wealth allow their possessors to disproportionately influence politics and policy-making, to engage in forms of consumption that are highly polluting, and, in some countries, even to buy citizenship.

(251)

Robeyns defines her central concept of a ‘limitarian threshold’ as the (‘richness’) ‘line above which [...] no one should be situated’ (253). She advocates:

redistribution that takes away the money above the limitarian threshold to reallocate it below the threshold or to use it for funding public goods

via policies including wage and wealth regulation and caps on the lifetime inheritance level. The participants in this study (Robeyns et al. 2021) drew the richness line or limitarian threshold between €1 million and €3 million annually.⁴ Limitarianism thus emphasises the aspect of redistribution which is missing in most sufficiency approaches. Though there is agreement with the mentioned sufficiency approaches that everyone should have their basic needs met, limitarianism provides an:

explicit focus on the bearers of the costs—those from whom the resources for redistribution will be taken or those who will have fewer resources (compared with the pre-limitarian situation) due to measures such as a maximum income legislation or a cap on inheritance.

(Robeyns 2022: 265)

Since extreme wealth and economic elites presently belong to the greatest obstacles towards generalising sufficiency principles on a constrained planet and preventing the redistributive policies Robeyns advocates, the next section discusses the contributions that specialists on this social group—elite researchers—provide to understand these obstacles in more detail.

Toulouse et al. (2019: 333) list some of the most significant barriers to (energy) sufficiency dissemination. These include the relative invisibility and intangibility of energy use in daily social practices, presumed welfare and wellbeing losses in the event of a policy turn towards sufficiency as well as dominating values and norms oriented at individual upward mobility and expansion in material terms. These authors also identify future research priorities including the theoretical understanding and empirical analysis of the cultural, social and psychological factors that can facilitate or complicate the implementation of sufficiency principles and policies. Though they generally encourage studies into ‘power dynamics and better identifying who might benefit or lose from sufficiency’ (334), they stop short of suggesting relevant or responsible actors or at least candidates in this regard that corresponding research should address. Recent contributions on the ‘polluter elite’ (Kenner 2019; IPCC 2022) go a step further: the provision of sufficiency for the many is here understood as being undermined by the social practices of privileged minorities who lead ecologically ungeneralisable lifestyles. Remaining carbon budgets are being depleted faster as a corollary (Gössling & Humpe 2023).

3. RESEARCH ON ELITES

One of ‘key ideologies’ of capitalist societies holds that:

economic rewards are distributed according to merit, where those who work hard or whose skills are in high demand get ahead.

(Lierse et al. 2022: 368)

This contrasts, however, with the observed intergenerational persistence of wealth inequality (Barone & Moretti 2020) which makes it:

difficult even for high-income earners to counter the historical weight of past wealth accumulation for those born into wealthy families.

(Lierse et al. 2022; see also Chancel & Piketty 2021)

In a context of increasing inequalities, elite research, just as sufficiency research, has enjoyed a recent upsurge (Cousin *et al.* 2018; Savage & Hjelbrekke 2021; Denord *et al.* 2020; Korsnes *et al.* 2017; Engelstad *et al.* 2019; Vogel *et al.* 2019). New concepts such as ‘plutocrats’ (Freeland 2012), ‘the super-rich’ or ‘rich oligarchs’ (Schimpfössl 2018) attempt to cover patterns of wealth accumulation and have started to point to the detrimental effects corresponding elite lifestyles have for the planet (Otto *et al.* 2019; Kenner 2019; Wiedmann *et al.* 2020). Scholarly understandings of how elites uphold their status as practices of differentiation include ‘boundary-work’ (Lamont 1992) and ‘distinction’ (Bourdieu 1984). These are complemented by theories of ‘imitation’ (Veblen 1899) to capture practices of elite lifestyle emulation. Concepts such as ‘status signalling’ (upgrading and adapting exclusive cultural habits), ‘hyperopia’ (denial and neglect of consequences of wealth and inequalities) and ‘omnivorousness’ (cultural appropriation of lower social groups) further help us understand social practices that normalise and sometimes naturalise elite lifestyles (Kuusela 2020).

There are at least three ways in which elite research may enrich the sufficiency debate in general and help one to understand the barriers to the dissemination of sufficiency principles in particular: first, elite research focuses on processes and struggles at the ‘top’ of society; second, it qualifies the debate on wants and needs by adding the category of ‘having’; and third, it illuminates how processes and practices that are ecologically ungeneralisable are nevertheless socially legitimised.

3.1 UNDERSTANDING ELITES AND THE FIELD OF POWER IN THE SOCIAL-ECOLOGICAL TRANSFORMATION

Limitarianism research suggests regulating wealth, economic elites and their resources beyond certain thresholds. Though the case for redistribution from the rich to the poor is certainly strong, it is complicated by the fact that, due to different existing definitions, elites can hardly be regarded as a homogeneous group. For example, a range of novel concepts attempts to unpack wealth levels and their different connections to unsustainable lifestyles. Terms such as 1%, 0.1% or ‘ultra-high-net-worth individuals’ (Atkinson *et al.* 2017) all capture those at the top, but apply different boundaries. Such categorical distinctions are reflected by different perceptions among the population of who may count as rich and extremely rich.

Elite research can contribute some clarification here. Following Khan (2012: 361), elites may be defined as actors who ‘have vastly disproportionate control over or access to a resource’ and thus can exercise societal influence. As long as the income distribution continues to be extremely skewed and the concentration of wealth continues to increase, this definition may be applied to the ‘super-rich’ or ‘super-wealthy’ population without much problem. Hence, populations that are empirically identified in these terms or as ‘economic elite’ most likely overlap. However, the term ‘elite’ presupposes at least a certain degree of power and authority tied to elite positions (Scott 2008). Some people with extreme wealth lack such formal authority associated with corporate powers, while those in command posts are not necessarily extremely rich. To understand elite practices and impacts comprehensively, it does not suffice to analyse their relations vis-à-vis lower classes and groups—how elites manage to keep subordinate classes and groups in their places and maintain their positions on top. The struggles within the dominant class itself must also be considered.

The Bourdieusean tradition has focused on the ‘power struggles among the holders of different forms of power’ (Bourdieu 1996: 265); economic and cultural capital in particular. The struggles within this upper region of social space are understood in analogy to a ‘gaming space’ in which those agents and institutions:

possessing enough specific capital [...] to be able to occupy the dominant positions within their respective fields confront each other using strategies aimed at preserving or transforming these relations of power.

(265)

Extending from the economic field to the field of cultural reproduction, the division of labour within the field of power is itself subject to historical and social transformations, with corresponding varying roles for:

(266)

The Marxian tradition has stressed additional divisions among the economic pole of the dominant class, between transnationally and domestically oriented factions (Sklair 2001; Robinson 2004).

In summary, the research on economic and other elites has provided definitions for the sorts of people who may count as ‘elites’. It addressed material and symbolic reproduction strategies in operation within national fields of power to preserve and improve elite positions in social space. It has raised critical questions including what kinds and amounts of capital were at play in particular periods of time and countries and how these were transmitted. New research projects could explore how national fields of power are affected by the ecological crisis, governmental and popular responses to it and how this impacts on elite reproduction strategies.

A first attempt is now evident to contextualise economic elites within processes of social–ecological transformation. Complementing previous contributions towards a critical understanding of environmental justice (e.g. Faber 2008; Pellow 2017), Kenner (2019) stresses the interrelated ways in which the ‘polluter elite’ significantly worsens the climate performance of advanced capitalist countries such as the US. On top of the luxurious carbon-intense lifestyles and consumption patterns, polluter elites influence sustainability outcomes through ‘investment emissions’ due to their control of shares of large corporations. Furthermore, these elites lobby for continued government subsidies for oil and gas and fund campaigns with the result, if not the goal, of delaying investments in renewable energy development or electric vehicles. The concept, however, has a US bias and focuses on owners of the fossil-fuel industry. Hence, it could be asked whether certain corporate leaders within the ‘green energy’ sector should also be classified as being part of the ‘polluter elite’. Alternatively, they could be regarded as merely ‘super-rich’. Hence, if there is a new division within the field of power between fossil and green factions similar to that between domestic and transnational factions, a corresponding research area would be whether those elite groups that have invested in renewables could be exempted from the redistributive measures from the rich to the poor that limitarians suggest.

3.2 TO NEED, TO WANT AND TO ‘HAVE’

The concepts of needs and wants are at the core of debates on sufficiency and limitarianism, with social–ecological transformations requiring a political focus on and limitation of the latter. Supporting this claim, Chancel & Piketty (2015) calculated that, in 2015, the top 10% of emitters accounted for 45% of global CO₂-equivalent emissions and the bottom 50% for 13%. In 2019, the top 0.01% of wealthy individuals collectively emitted more than 2300 tons of CO₂e per capita compared with 6 tons per capita for the global average (Gössling & Humpe 2023). In other words, meeting the wants of the rich has a much higher carbon footprint than fulfilling the needs of the poorer parts of the population. This situation is aggravated by increasing wealth inequality and growing numbers of millionaires and billionaires (Credit Suisse 2021).

In a study of wealthy elites in London, a distinction was made between ‘those who have’ and ‘those who have yachts’ (Burrows & Knowles 2019) to shed light on the socio-spatial struggles between the ‘merely wealthy’ individuals (i.e. the ‘haves’) and the ‘transnational über-wealthy’ individuals (i.e. the ‘have yachts’). This distinction also reflects the fact that it is not only the working-class strata that is being affected by displacement but also parts of wealthier strata. The distinction thus sheds light on the extreme differences in the wealthy strata and how the ‘have yachts’ are taking over neighbourhoods through their excessive home reconstructions and consumption of décor, but also through their detached, individualistic and sometimes hidden lifestyles (cf. the concept of oysterisation below). It is not, however, only the extreme consumption and reconstruction patterns—including the increasing number of excavations under houses with up to two- and even three-storey basements for swimming pools, spas, cinemas, staff accommodation, etc.—that is highly problematic from an environmental perspective. From a social perspective it means that surrounding neighbours, i.e. mostly the ‘haves’, need to put up with protracted, tiresome, noisy and

polluting construction works together with the fact that the ‘have yachts’ share neither a common nor an emotional interest in the neighborhood, but merely a financial interest, contributing to a ‘sense of displacement and the feeling of being out of place’ among the ‘haves’ (Burrows & Knowles 2019: 83).

Connected to the discussions about excessive home reconstructions, which are highly energy-demanding in themselves, are the discussions about available space, appliance acquisition and energy-intensive practices (Sahakian 2018). Large available space comes with a ‘multiplying of appliances and powered devices’ and thus with an overall increase in energy consumption. In relation to the super-rich’s basement excavations, but also in relation to having second or third homes, Sahakian (2018: 66) states that:

it is not just a multiplying of appliances but a multiplying of all living space with the associated energy consumption for heating and cooling these homes.

It seems as though these wealthy individuals are not too bothered by these kinds of consumption practices, which might be due to them comparing themselves with others who consume even more. Legitimation and normalisation processes are also connected to social norms, such as tidiness, cleanliness and comfort (Sahakian 2018). Owning extreme luxury items such as private yachts or jets may in this sense be regarded as necessary prerequisites for elite status and expressions of the culture and norms associated with being super-rich (Featherstone 2013).

Processes of extreme wealth accumulation and supergentrification (Atkinson et al. 2017; Paulsen & Stuber 2022) enfold in parallel. As a result of the ‘heavily urbanised’ super-rich population being concentrated in ‘command centers of the global economy’, Atkinson et al. (2017) discuss the emergence of ‘plutocratic’ cities as spaces that are “‘bought” by and for the rich, by, with and for their capital’ (12). In such exclusive habitats, the extremely rich make use of personal drivers and discrete vehicles,

shops with manned doorways, fortress homes, gated communities and well-staffed private leisure and consumption spaces that symbolically or physically block access to those who do not belong.

(Atkinson 2016: 1304)

Given multiple systems of protection, what exactly the rich ‘have’ is hard to identify, never mind regulate, with ‘oysterisation’ functioning as a conscious or unconscious closure strategy (Atkinson 2016) for economic elites to continue living ecologically ungeneralisable lifestyles. ‘Having’ stands in this sense in opposition not only to ‘being’ (Fromm 2013) but also to the needs and wants of lower classes, making this category a significant structuration principle of contemporary capitalist society.

Persisting and increasing wealth inequalities can be traced to historical processes of widening power asymmetries between capital and labour (including traditionally aligned political parties). So-called ‘third way’ socialist or social-democratic governments either disposed of inheritance and/or wealth taxation or did not re-introduce these if other parties abolished such policy instruments previously. A further development that increased the structural power of, especially, mobile and financial capital, which found its expression in declining tax rates, were openings and ‘liberalisations’ of previously protected domestic markets. Even labour-oriented parties have pursued:

a social investment approach that emphasizes skill development and labour market activation at the expense of redistribution.

(Lierse et al. 2022: 370)

An important, albeit paradoxical, result from these developments is that being wealthy in general and wealth inequality in particular are not necessarily perceived as a problem. Hecht et al. (2022: 18) indicate that the more unequal societies become, the greater the share of the people who interpret richness—including ‘having’—as a necessary, legitimate and, hence, morally justified means of ‘being “safe” and “secure”’. They observe that when social protection systems weaken, as in the British context:

efforts to advocate for more effective and strongly progressive taxation, especially inheritance, property or wealth taxes which would contribute to a more equal society [...], often seem to meet with popular hostility.

(18–19)

This vicious circle between deregulating the welfare state, increasing inequality and raising its legitimacy among the electorate constitutes an enormous structural barrier to the generalisation of sufficiency principles of which policymakers should be aware.

3.3 LEGITIMATION OF THE UNGENERALIZABLE: FROM RULE-TAKERS TO RULE-MAKERS

The empirical trend of increasing concentrations of income and wealth at the top has given rise to new political proposals for taxing capital and wealth (Piketty *et al.* 2023) at both national and global levels (Kapeller *et al.* 2023). Yet these political initiatives appear to be somewhat at odds with central results of elite research. The latter indicates a role reversal between policymakers and economic elites, suggesting that those in economic command posts increasingly act as (political legislative) ‘rule-makers’ rather than ‘rule-takers’ (Mills 1956/2000; Streeck & Thelen 2005). Corresponding empirical investigations find economic elites to be difficult to hold to account, tax-dodging, and mobile between places and country borders.

They move in different worlds along privileged pathways. They are off land in their super yachts [...] their assets are offshore, and if they are not at sea, they are in their private jets or luxury penthouses.

(Forrest *et al.* 2017: 7)

On top of their direct and very material impact on investment decisions and policymaking via their control of extensive economic resources and formal leadership positions, economic elites dispose of huge amounts of symbolic capital (Bourdieu 1984, 1996). Sociological elite theories portray elites as sources of inspiration and producers of legitimate norms of what is considered a worthy and good lifestyle. Since acquiring as much wealth as possible has long counted, and still counts, as a sign of social success, elites can act as role models for others, including policymakers. They are producers of status and meaning through their cultural products, habits and modes of cultural consumption (Veblen 1899). The result of the interaction between elite tastemakers and lower-class competitors is a complex status game in which elites seek to maintain exclusivity and limitless lifestyles. Through emulation and imitation, large parts of the middle classes try to climb social ladders and become more like those at the top (Friedman & Reeves 2020). At the same time, elites have sought to protect their privileged positions through even more exclusive cultural practices, including luxury (Khan 2012) and conspicuous (Veblen 1899) consumption. It is the trickle-down effect of what used to be luxury goods to the lower classes that leads to the consumption of ever more exclusive cultural practices and tastes on the part of elites (Bellezza 2022). Many of these practices are ecologically unaffordable if the climate crisis were taken seriously. A good example is air travel, which used to function as a status signal for the privileged few. Its economic and social devaluation due to cheaper ticket prices forced elites to use private jets instead of ordinary business class to maintain status differences.

Patterns of material and symbolic distinction of the extreme wealthy vis-à-vis lower classes are blurred and upheld by subtle practices through which the former downplay social differences. The emphasis on their own hard work—not the appropriated work of others—and individual achievements as underlying and main sources of their wealth (de Vries & Reeves 2022; Jarness & Friedman 2017) is an almost classical example (Koch 2018). Accordingly, elites present themselves as deserving achievers (Friedman *et al.* 2021) who have gained their position due to merit rather than privilege (Sherman 2018; O’Brien & Ianni 2023). The degree to which the climate crisis and sustainability discourses cause modifications of such legitimization strategies is presently unclear and in need of empirical investigation. Elites may seek to disclose and misrecognise the climate effects of their practices, e.g. through off-setting strategies. A typical example is climate philanthropy:

wealthy individuals exchange their economic resources for the legitimacy of supporting worthy and desirable causes such as climate change mitigation or adaption (Maclean et al. 2021; Krauz-Lahav & Kemp 2020). The Giving Pledge is another interesting case where some of the world's wealthiest people commit to give most of their wealth to pressing problems to 'set a new standard of generosity among the ultra-wealthy'. It started in the US and continues to spread around the world. Being associated with donations and philanthropic activities not only signals that elites have a sense of, and responsibility for, the community, but also provides a means of normalising and legitimising their wealth and status as morally acceptable despite increasing social inequalities (Krauz-Lahav & Kemp 2020; Maclean et al. 2021; Sherman 2018). However, the social and political pressure to take the climate crisis seriously is likely to push elites into new areas of symbolic capital investment which should be explored further. Corresponding exchanges of economic resources for the legitimacy that comes with being associated with climate philanthropy generally serve the goal of maintaining positions at the top in times of planetary crisis; such voluntary initiatives are also a useful means to avoid state regulation such as compulsory wealth taxation.

4. TOWARDS A NEW RESEARCH AGENDA

The academic engagement with the ecological crisis, sufficiency and limitarianism, on the one hand, and social inequality and elite studies, on the other, suggests the development of a research agenda that considers and unifies the knowledge from both scholarly traditions. The point of departure for such an agenda is closing the dual gap that currently divides sufficiency research and elite research. Sustainability and sufficiency research points to an academic void in elite research, which has focused almost exclusively on social inequality and the patterns of its reproduction (Johansson & Uhlin 2020; Savage & Hjellbrekke 2021), but has generally shown little interest in the roles of elites in causing, aggravating and (perhaps) mitigating climate change and other environmental threats. Conversely, social-science sustainability, including sufficiency, scholars have mostly studied socio-economically disadvantaged groups and how these are affected by climate change and the ecological crisis, often stressing North/South divides (Walker 2012). Much less explored is wealth concentration as an eco-social problem, its spatial expression especially in cities, and the underlying social, political and symbolic power of economic elites. This is unfortunate since such research could constitute a sociological complementation to the existing mostly economic notion of a 'polluter elite'. By focusing on those in power, in both their network of relations vis-à-vis the subaltern and their mutual relations within the field of power, elite research has a great deal to say about why sufficiency principles have *not* generalised so far—an insight that may be considered indispensable in building the kind of counter-hegemony that sufficiency-oriented movements intend to achieve.

Hence, there is a need for a further exploration of the potentials for mutual cross-fertilisation between the sufficiency and elite research fields. At least five avenues seem to follow from the present discussion. First, though existing research has demonstrated that extreme wealth comes with disproportionate ecological footprints, there is a lack of knowledge as to how exactly wealthy individuals and economic elites execute their power resources in relation to climate change and social-ecological transformations. This knowledge gap suggests further studies of corresponding elite discourses, identities and representations, strategies of influence and legitimation, as well as elite perceptions and experiences of climate crisis and associated pressures towards social-ecological transformation. How do elites respond to the ecological crisis, what are their ideas as to how to solve it, and what are the discrepancies between the views of elites and the public? Such research topics are especially relevant given the tendency of exoticising elites and their lifestyles in public, media and scholarly discourse (Forrest et al. 2017).⁵ While it is certainly true that elites lead different lives than the vast majority of citizens, not much is known about how exactly elites navigate the increasingly fragile balance of wealth accumulation and consolidation of legitimacy during the climate crisis. Corresponding studies could explore how economic elites present themselves and are presented in connection with climate change and social-ecological transformations in and beyond the media, and what legitimation and justification strategies and 'generosity' initiatives they use (considering different types of economic elites, their relationships to the state and policymakers).

Second, a comparative perspective is likely to increase the scholarly yield of this line of research. While national fields of power in advanced societies share some commonalities such as the division of labour between economic and material, and cultural and symbolic capital, countries nonetheless differ regarding institutional set-up, the historical legacy of wealth concentration as well as political and public support for redistributive policies. At the same time, climate change and social-ecological transformations will affect all societies and their elites. This context may turn out to be ‘the perfect storm’ capable of changing traditional elite compositions and paving the way either for implementing effective wealth and income regulations or voluntary changes towards more sustainable behaviour patterns among wealthy individuals, or a combination of the two. Cross-country research could address elite preferences and strategies in relation to either line of change. Comparisons of countries (and of different factions of national economic elites) is furthermore likely to produce insights into how factors such as national institutional regime types and elite cultures influence elite responses to social-ecological transformations, and how these vary across elite factions and political, business and public domains.

Third, the combined research agenda suggests methodological pluralism and triangulations of literature and media analyses to capture representations of and by elites concerning climate change and environmental crisis, semi-structured qualitative interviews with elite representatives themselves, (vignette) surveys to measure public support of political regulation measures as well as citizen forums to generate corresponding eco-social policy ideas collectively. Such variegated empirical insights will allow for deeper understandings of the barriers to and opportunities for sufficiency principles to occur. It is indeed ‘unrealistic’ (Dubuisson-Quellier 2022: 44) that the dissemination of sufficiency can exclusively ‘rest on the shoulders of consumers’ or the behavioural change of individuals at large. The social sciences can provide the required ‘systemic vision’ on processes of social-ecological transformation and shed light on the links between consumption and production norms as well as the interests and power asymmetries among the actors involved, and particularly the role of elites in causing the social-ecological crisis and responding to it.

Fourth, a series of questions arise concerning the type(s) of policy reforms the public finds acceptable, both generally in relation to the 2015 United Nations’ Paris Agreement on climate change and specifically regarding the rich, and how such support differs across social groups and experts. Explorations of how the public views elites, their practices and privileges are central to understand these support rates. However, information and appeals to voluntary behavioural changes are very unlikely to result in the amount of reduction in energy consumption necessary to seriously address the environmental crises. Yet stronger regulation of wealth and the rich is complicated by the somewhat paradoxical ways in which inequality is currently being perceived: although benefitting elites, the public concern about inequality has decreased with citizens in comparatively more unequal societies being less worried than those in more egalitarian societies (Hecht et al. 2022: 2). Though excess energy consumption and the general aggravation of the social-ecological crisis suggests increasingly radical policy measures capable of initiating structural change to grapple with inequality and ecological crisis at the same time, the public appears to embrace this in parts at best (Cass et al. 2023: 9). In this situation, the expansion of the general knowledge of the detrimental effects elite lifestyles have for the climate and the wellbeing of future generations appears to be the necessary precondition for increasing public support for critical eco-social political measures, such as the implementation of caps on income and wealth (François et al. 2023).

Fifth, scholars can help increase public support for such eco-social policies by organising and facilitating policy forums and applying what Gough (2017) refers to as the ‘dual strategy’ of policy formation. This method combines the expert knowledge of researchers with the practical knowledge of citizens and local stakeholders to identify the goods and services necessary for needs satisfaction within a particular social and cultural context and environmental limits. While such deliberative forums are locally and temporally specific, their outcomes have in different societal contexts helped to critically review policy goals, behaviours, satisfiers and infrastructures, and led to adaptations in long-term policy planning, which were, in some cases, upscaled to the national level. Guillén-Royo (2016) provides examples for this from Spain, Peru and Norway (for Sweden, see Lee et al. 2023).

The dissemination and implementation of sufficiency principles is impossible without limiting the ecologically ungeneralisable lifestyles of the rich. The point of departure for this article was that existing sufficiency research has not systematically considered the impact of economic elites on society, environment and the potentials for social–ecological transformations. The article has outlined how an integration with elite research may help sufficiency research to fill this gap, and demonstrated that the roles that economic elites play in society in general and social–ecological transformations in particular may be divided into direct and indirect impacts. Their direct impact via investment decisions and luxury lifestyles is now being reflected by the IPCC (2022: 529), which has started to refer to the extreme rich, following Kenner (2019), as the ‘polluter elite’. The indirect, mostly symbolic, role that elites play as tastemakers and role models remains, however, largely underexplored within sufficiency circles. While philosophical limitarianism criticises elite lifestyles as being ungeneralisable within planetary boundaries, social and political mobilisations in connection with the current economic downturn, debates on ‘flight shame’ and Fridays for Future protests push for redistributive reforms that reduce extreme wealth and provide a more just distribution of the burdens of climate change mitigation and adaptation. Since wealth requires a minimal degree of social acceptance to still be considered legitimate, economic elites are under constant pressure to adapt and find ways to re-legitimise their lifestyles. Despite growing recognition of the detrimental effects of excessive wealth for nature and society, there is a lack of empirical studies that explore how economic elites themselves respond to the social–ecological crisis, their interpretations of this crisis and ideas as to how to solve it, as well as potential discrepancies between the views of elites and the public.

This article has indicated the general direction such research should take and suggested empirical studies that investigate how economic elites craft their role in connection to climate change, sufficiency and limits, and how this is perceived by the public. Of special importance is the exploration of structural barriers to the dissemination of sufficiency principles here operationalised as the symbolic power that elites have over the public in times of ecological crisis and the structural potentials for political resistance from lower social classes to make current economic elites respect planetary limits in the future.

NOTES

- 1 In Scandinavia, less than 10% of the Swedish population supports the policy suggestion of limiting the living space per person. Just 27% are in favour of imposing a cap on wealth and incomes (Lee et al. 2023: 837).
- 2 Policy ideas to alter these developments stretch from facilitations of co- or shared housing (including intergenerational) to reduce the average amount of square metreage used by individuals via transformations of home ownership to social housing, caps on average dwellings floors and requisitions to ideas of ‘simpler living’ (Trainer 2019) to reduce the energy amounts used in individual dwellings (Toulouse et al. 2019).
- 3 To paraphrase Bertolt Brecht’s poem *Alfabet* (1934) (in English *Alphabet*; Brecht/Willet & Manheim 1934/1976: ‘R’, 241): the poor would not be poor if the rich were not rich.
- 4 Rather than simply asking people where to draw such a line, which may well prove ‘too difficult’ (Robeyns et al. 2021: 118), vignettes were used. Response and support rates for such a riches line seem to increase if embedded in concrete descriptions of scenarios (vignettes), including how the extra revenue would be spent.
- 5 There is a general fascination with the super-rich indicated by the popularity of television series such as *Succession*.

AUTHOR AFFILIATIONS

Max Koch  orcid.org/0000-0003-0932-3570
School of Social Work, Lund University, Lund, SE

COMPETING INTERESTS

The authors declare they have no competing interests.

FUNDING

This research was funded by FORMAS, the Swedish Research Council for Sustainable Development (grant number 2023-01771), project ‘Economic Elites in the Climate Change Transformation: Practices, Justifications and Regulations of Unsustainable Lifestyles in Sweden’. The article benefited from additional funding from FORMAS, the Swedish Research Council for Sustainable Development (grant number 2023-00473), project ‘Regulating the Polluter Elite: Exploring policy measures limiting carbon footprints of the rich’.

REFERENCES

- Atkinson, R. (2016). Limited exposure: Social concealment, mobility and engagement with public space by the super-rich in London. *Environment and Planning*, 48(7), 1302–1317. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1177/0308518X15598323>
- Atkinson, R. (2018). Necrotexture: Lifeless dwellings and London’s super-rich. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research*, 43(1), 2–13. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1111/1468-2427.12707>
- Atkinson, R., Parker, S., & Burrows, R. (2017). Elite formation, power and space in contemporary London. *Theory, Culture and Society*, 34(5–6), 179–200. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1177/0263276417717792>
- Bärnthaler, R., & Gough, I. (2023). Provisioning for sufficiency: Envisaging production Corridors. *Sustainability: Science, Practice and Policy*, 19(1). DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1080/15487733.2023.2218690>
- Barone, G., & Moretti, S. (2020). Intergenerational mobility in the very long run: Florence 1427–2011. *Review of Economic Studies*, 88(4), 1863–1893. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1093/restud/rdaa075>
- Bellezza, S. (2022). Distance and alternative signals of status: A unifying framework. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 50(2), 322–342. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1093/jcr/ucac049>
- Bierwirth, A., & Thomas, S. (2019). Estimating the sufficiency potential in buildings: The space between underdimensioned and oversized. *ECEEE Summer Study Proceedings*. <https://epub.wupperinst.org/frontdoor/index/index/docId/7332>
- Bourdieu, P. (1984). *Distinction: A social critique of judgement and taste*. Harvard University Press.
- Bourdieu, P. (1996). *The state nobility. Elite schools in the field of power*. Stanford University Press. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1515/9781503615427>
- Brecht, B. (1934/1976). ‘Five children’s songs: “Alphabet”’ [1934]. In J. Willet & R. Manheim (Eds.), *Bertolt Brecht: Plays, poetry, prose* (pp. 239–242). Eyre Methuen.
- Burrows, R., & Knowles, C. (2019). The ‘HAVES’ and the ‘HAVE YACHTS’: Socio-spatial struggles in London between the ‘merely wealthy’ and the ‘super-rich’. *Cultural Politics*, 15(1), 72–87. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1215/17432197-7289528>
- Cass, N., Büchs, M., & Lucas, K. (2023). How are high-carbon lifestyles justified? Exploring the discursive strategies of excess energy consumers in the United Kingdom. *Energy Research & Social Science*, 97, 102951. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.erss.2023.102951>
- Chancel, L., & Piketty, T. (2015). *Carbon and inequality: From Kyoto to Paris*. 01-Study-PSE-4decNUMERIQUE-1.pdf (ens.fr)
- Chancel, L., & Piketty, T. (2021). Global income inequality, 1820–2020: The persistence and mutation of extreme inequality. *Journal of the European Economic Association*, 19(6), 3025–3062. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1093/jeaa/jvab047>
- Cousin, B., Khan, S., & Mears, A. (2018). Theoretical and methodological pathways for research on elites. *Socio-Economic Review*, 16(2), 225–249. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1093/ser/mwy019>
- Credit Suisse. (2021). *Global wealth databook 2021*. <https://www.credit-suisse.com/about-us/en/reports-research/studies-publications.html>

- Darby, S., & Fawcett, T. (2018). Energy sufficiency—An introduction: A concept paper for ECEEE. <https://www.energysufficiency.org/static/media/uploads/site-8/library/papers/sufficiency-introduction-final-oct2018.pdf>
- Davis, A., Stone, J., Blackwell, C., Padley, M., Shepherd, C., & Hirsch, D. (2022). A minimum income standard for the United Kingdom in 2022 (Report). Loughborough University. <https://hdl.handle.net/2134/21206114.v1>
- de Vries, R., & Reeves, A. (2022). What does it mean to be a cultural omnivore? Conflicting visions of omnivorosity in empirical research. *Sociological Research Online*, 27(2), 292–312. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1177/13607804211006109>
- Denord, F., Palme, M., & Reau, B. (Eds.) (2020). *Researching elites and power. Theory, methods, analyses*. Springer. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-45175-2>
- Doyal, L., & Gough, I. (1991). *A theory of human need*. Macmillan. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-1-349-21500-3>
- Dubuisson-Quellier, S. (2022). How does affluent consumption come to consumers? A research agenda for exploring the foundations and lock-ins of affluent consumption. *Consumption & Society*, 1(1), 31–50. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1332/UHIW3894>
- Engelstad, F., Gulbrandsen, T., Mangset, M., & Teigen, M. (2019). Elites and people: Challenges to democracy. *Comparative Social Research*, 34, 1–13. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1108/S0195-631020190000034001>
- Faber, D. (2008). *Capitalizing on environmental injustice. The polluter–industrial complex in an age of globalization*. Rowman & Littlefield.
- Featherstone, M. (2013). Super-rich lifestyles. In T. Birtchnell & J. Caletrio (Eds.), *Elite mobilities* (pp. 99–135). Routledge.
- Forrest, R., Koh, S. Y., & Wissink, B. (2017). In search of the super-rich: Who are they? Where are they? In Forrest, R., Koh, S., & Wissink, B. (Eds.), *Cities and the super-rich. The contemporary city* (pp. 229–252). Palgrave Macmillan. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1057/978-1-137-54834-4>
- François, M., Mertens de Wilmars, S., & Maréchal, K. (2023). Unlocking the potential of income and wealth caps in post-growth transformation: A framework for improving policy design. *Ecological Economics*, 208, 107788. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ecolecon.2023.107788>
- Freeland, C. (2012). *Plutocrats: The rise of the new global super rich and the fall of everyone else*. Allen Lane.
- Friedman, S., O'Brien, D., & McDonald, I. (2021). Deflecting privilege: Class identity and the intergenerational self. *Sociology*, 55(4), 716–733. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1177/0038038520982225>
- Friedman, S., & Reeves, A. (2020). From aristocratic to ordinary: Shifting modes of elite distinction. *American Sociological Review*, 85(2), 323–350. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1177/0003122420912941>
- Fromm, E. (2013). *To have or to be?* Bloomsbury.
- Fuchs, D., Sahakian, M., Gumbert, T. et al. (2021). *Consumption corridors: Living a good life within sustainable limits*. Routledge.
- Gössling, S., & Humpe, A. (2023). Millionaire spending incompatible with 1.5°C ambitions. *Cleaner Production Letters*, 4, 100027. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.clpl.2022.100027>
- Gough, I. (2017). *Heat, greed and human need*. Edward Elgar. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.4337/9781785365119>
- Guillén-Royo, M. (2016). *Sustainability and wellbeing: Human scale development in practice*. Routledge.
- Hecht, K., Burchardt, T., & Davis, A. (2022). Richness, insecurity and the welfare state. *Journal of Social Policy*, 53(3), 573–594. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0047279422000617>
- IPBES. (2022). *Methodological assessment report on the diverse values and valuation of nature of the Intergovernmental Science-Policy Platform on Biodiversity and Ecosystem Services*. IPBES secretariat.
- IPCC. (2022). *Climate change 2022: Mitigation of climate change*. ipcc.ch
- Jarness, V., & Friedman, S. (2017). 'I'm not a snob but ...' Class boundaries and the downplaying of difference. *Poetics*, 61, 14–25. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.poetic.2016.11.001>
- Johansson, H., & Uhlin, A. (2020). Civil society elites. A research agenda. *Politics and Governance*, 8(3), 82–85. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.17645/pag.v8i3.3572>
- Jungell-Michelsson, J., & Heikkurinen, P. (2022). Sufficiency: A systematic literature review. *Ecological Economics*, 195, 107380. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ecolecon.2022.107380>
- Kapeller, J., Leitch, S., & Wildauer, R. (2023). Can a European wealth tax close the green investment gap? *Ecological Economics*, 209, 107849. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ecolecon.2023.107849>
- Kenner, D. (2019). *Carbon inequality: The role of the richest in climate change*. Routledge. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351171328>
- Khan, J., Emilsson, K., Fritz, M., Koch, M., Hildingsson, R., & Johansson, H. (2023). Ecological ceiling and social floor: Public support for eco-social policies in Sweden. *Sustainability Science*, 18, 1519–1532. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11625-022-01221-z>
- Khan, S. R. (2012). The sociology of elites. *Annual Review of Sociology*, 38(1), 361–377. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-soc-071811-145542>

- Koch, M.** (2018). The naturalisation of growth: Marx, the regulation approach and Bourdieu. *Environmental Values*, 27(1), 9–27. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.3197/096327118X15144698637504>
- Koch, M., Büchs, M., & Lee, J.** (2023). Towards a new generation of social policy: Commonalities between sustainable welfare and the IPCC. *Politiche Sociali/Social Policies*, 1, 27–42. DOI: <https://www.rivisteweb.it/doi/10.7389/107137>
- Korsnes, O., Heilbron, J., Hjelbrekke, J., Bühlmann, F., & Savage, M.** (Eds.). (2017). *New directions in elite studies*. Taylor & Francis. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315163796>
- Krauz-Lahav, N., & Kemp, A.** (2020). Elite without elitism? Boundary work and the Israeli elite philanthropy in a changing field of power. *Social Problems*, 67(2), 324–341. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1093/socpro/spz015>
- Kuusela, H.** (2020). The hyperopia of wealth: The cultural legitimization of economic inequalities by top earners. *Socio-Economic Review*, 20(2), 515–538. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1093/ser/mwaa047>
- Lamont, M.** (1992). *Money, morals, manners*. University of Chicago Press. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.7208/chicago/9780226922591.001.0001>
- Lee, J., Koch, M., & Alkan-Olsson, J.** (2023). Deliberating a sustainable welfare–work nexus. *Politische Vierteljahresschrift/German Political Science Quarterly*, 64, 825–844. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11615-023-00454-6>
- Lierse, H., Sachweh, P., & Waitkus, N.** (2022). Introduction: Wealth, inequality and redistribution in capitalist societies. *Social Justice Research*, 35, 367–378. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11211-022-00402-6>
- Lorek, S., & Spangenberg, J. H.** (2019). Energy sufficiency through social innovation in housing. *Energy Policy*, 126, 287–294. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.enpol.2018.11.026>
- Macleane, M., Harvey, C., Yang, R., & Mueller, F.** (2021). Elite philanthropy in the United States and United Kingdom in the new age of inequalities. *International Journal of Management Reviews*, 23(3), 330–352. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1111/ijmr.12247>
- Mills, C. W.** (1956/2000). *The Power Elite*. Oxford University Press.
- Nelson, A.** (2019). Housing for growth narratives. In Nelson, A., & Schneider, F. (Eds.), *Housing for degrowth* (pp. 3–13). Routledge. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315151205-1>
- O'Brien, D., & Ianni, L.** (2023). New forms of distinction: How contemporary cultural elites understand ‘good’ taste. *Sociological Review*, 71(1), 201–220. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1177/00380261221128144>
- Otto, I. M., Kim, K. M., Dubrovsky, N., & Lucht, W.** (2019). Shift the focus from the super-poor to the super-rich. *Nature Climate Change*, 9(2), 82–84. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41558-019-0402-3>
- Padley, M., & Hirsch, D.** (2017). *A minimum income standard for the UK in 2017*. York: Joseph Rowntree Foundation.
- Paulsen, K. E., & Stuber, J.** (2022). On place and privilege: Varieties of affluence in cities and neighborhoods. *Sociology Compass*, 16(6), e12981. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1111/soc4.12981>
- Pellow, D. W.** (2017). *What is critical environmental justice?* Polity. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1017/9781316418369.020>
- Piketty, T., Saez, E., & Zucman, G.** (2023). Rethinking capital and wealth taxation. *Oxford Review of Economic Policy*, 39, 575–591. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1093/oxrep/grad026>
- Rees, W. E.** (2009). The ecological crisis and self-delusion: Implications for the building sector. *Building Research & Innovation*, 37(3), 300–311. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1080/09613210902781470>
- Robeyns, I.** (2017). Having too much. *Nomos*, 58, 1–44. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/26785948>. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.18574/nyu/9781479827008.003.0001>
- Robeyns, I.** (2022). Why limitarianism? *Journal of Political Philosophy*, 30(2), 149–270. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1111/jopp.12275>
- Robeyns, I., Buskens, V., van de Rijt, A., Vergeldt, N., & van der Lippe, T.** (2021). How rich is too rich? Measuring the riches line. *Social Indicators Research*, 154, 115–143. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11205-020-02552-z>
- Robinson, W.** (2004). *A theory of global capitalism. Production, class, and state in a transnational world*. JHU Press. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.56021/9780801878848>
- Sahakian, M.** (2018). Constructing normality through material and social lock-in: The dynamics of energy consumption among Geneva’s more affluent households. In Hui, A., Day, R., & Walker, G. (Eds.) *Demanding energy: Space, time and change* (pp. 51–71). Palgrave. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-61991-0_3
- Savage, M., & Hjelbrekke, J.** (2021). *The sociology of elites: A European stocktaking and call for collaboration* (Working Papers). International Inequalities Institute, London School of Economics and Political Science (LSE).
- Schimpfössl, E.** (2018). *Rich Russians: From oligarchs to bourgeoisie*. Oxford University Press. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780190677763.001.0001>
- Schneider, F.** (2019). Housing for degrowth narratives. In Nelson, A., & Schneider, F. (Eds.), *Housing for degrowth* (pp. 14–30). Routledge. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315151205-2>

- Scott, J.** (2008). Modes of power and the re-conceptualization of elites. *Sociological Review*, 56(Suppl. 1), 25–43. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-954X.2008.00760.x>
- Sherman, R.** (2018). 'A very expensive ordinary life': Consumption, symbolic boundaries, and moral legitimacy among New York elites. *Socio-Economic Review*, 16(2), 411–433. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1093/ser/mwy011>
- Sklair, L.** (2001). *The transnational capitalist class*. Oxford University Press.
- Spengler, L.** (2016). Two types of 'enough': Sufficiency as minimum and maximum. *Environmental Politics*, 25(2), 921–940. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1080/09644016.2016.1164355>
- Streeck, W., & Thelen, K.** (2005). Introduction: Institutional change in advanced political economies. In Streeck, W., & Thelen, K. (Eds.), *Beyond continuity: Institutional change in advanced political economies* (pp. 1–39). Oxford University Press. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780199280452.003.0001>
- Toulouse, E., Sahakian, M., Bohnenberger, K., Bierwirth, A., Lorek, S., & Leuser, L.** (2019). Energy sufficiency: How can research better help and inform policy-making? https://epub.wupperinst.org/frontdoor/deliver/index/docId/7399/file/7399_Toulouse.pdf
- Trainer, T.** (2019). The simpler way: Housing, living and settlements. In Nelson, A., & Schneider, F. (Eds.), *Housing for degrowth* (pp. 120–131). Routledge. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315151205-10>
- Veblen, T.** (1899). *The theory of the leisure class: An economic study*. Allen & Unwin.
- Vogel, L., Gebauer, R., & Salheiser, A.** (2019). *The contested status of political elites: At the crossroads*. Routledge. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315211916>
- Walker, G.** (2012). *Environmental justice: Concepts, evidence and politics*. Routledge.
- Wiedmann, T., Lenzen, M., Keyßer, L. T. et al.** (2020). Scientists' warning on affluence. *Nature Communications*, 11, 3107. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-020-16941-y>

TO CITE THIS ARTICLE:

Koch, M., Emilsson, K., Lee, J., & Johansson, H. (2024). Structural barriers to sufficiency: the contribution of research on elites. *Buildings and Cities*, 5(1), pp. 268–282. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.5334/bc.439>

Submitted: 12 April 2024

Accepted: 05 July 2024

Published: 19 July 2024

COPYRIGHT:

© 2024 The Author(s). This is an open-access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License (CC-BY 4.0), which permits unrestricted use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original author and source are credited. See <http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>.

Buildings and Cities is a peer-reviewed open access journal published by Ubiquity Press.